

207 Identify wader bill shapes

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The next time you're at the beach, look at the birds walking and feeding along the shoreline. These are waders, and they have some of the most amazing bills. See which ones you can spot.

What you need

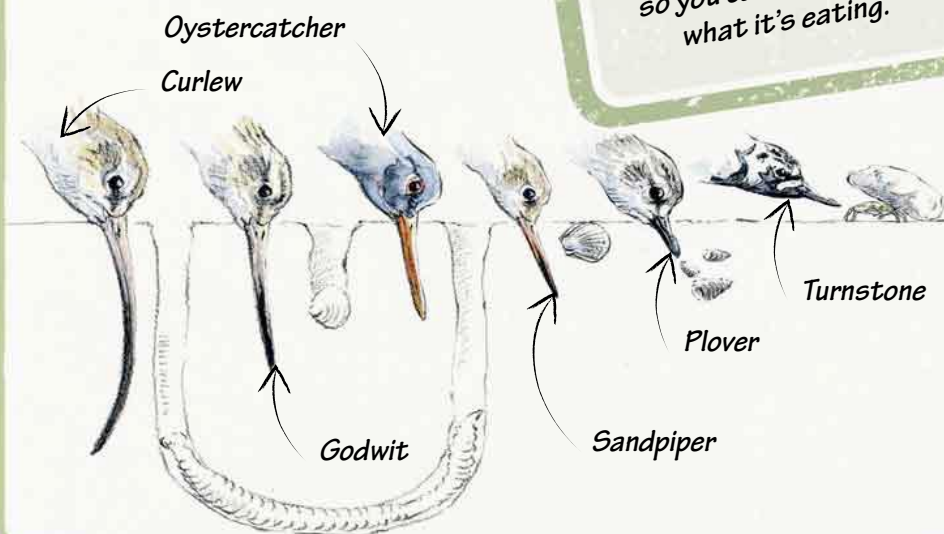
- Binoculars
- A guide to wader bill shapes (see below)

1 Waders' bills come in many lengths and shapes, to allow their owners to feed on different foods. What kinds can you see?

2 Long, curved bills let birds probe deep in the sand for lugworms. Oystercatchers use theirs to prize open mussel shells.

3 Short-billed waders like plovers and sandpipers feed on snails and clams that live closer to the surface.

Some waders wash their food before swallowing it, so you can see exactly what it's eating.



208 Sift a mudflat sample

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Mudflats can be tricky places, so take care when collecting a sample. Push the mud through a strainer. Mud snails, lugworms, tiny clams, and small worms should appear.

